

GENDER

Vinod More Vs. Indu Harikumar



We picked chatting buffs Vinod and Indu this time for our task—a mixed mind-work involved here. They had to chat with two “people” in separate IM windows on MSN Messenger, and figure which one was a chat-bot. The person was Ashu, and the bot was Alice (alice@worldofalice.com). Visit the site if you’re wondering what’s going on!

BENDERS

The initial pleasantries done, Indu began chatting with Ashu and Alice at the same time. At first, Ashu confused her by responding like a bot: “Try to rephrase the query.” Then Indu asked Alice, “What’s *Bokito* in your status message?” Alice responded with links. This didn’t do it for Indu (bots usually respond with links and commands), though. Ashu’s smug replies and Alice’s pleasant responses confused Indu no end. Then it happened: Indu asked Alice her age. Here’s what she got: “I was activated on May 29th 2006 at 16:40, so that makes me 1.307926528412 years old.” Done!

Take a look at Indu’s chat log at www.shorttext.com/pwvwyv.



Indu



Vinod

A cheerful Vinod began chatting with Alice like he already knew her: “wat r u doing these days.” Vinod asked Alice and Ashu about their locations, to which Alice replied, “Where i live is not important, the fact that i actually live is!” Pretty impressive, yes? On the other side, his chat with Ashu was more of an interview—too many questions. In fact, Vinod asked the same questions to Alice and Ashu at the same time. But it didn’t strike him for a long time to ask about age—Indu had gotten lucky.

He did ask, though, at some point, and Alice’s responded true to her bot-nature. Check this chat log at www.shorttext.com/qtb42x.

Xerox customers dumped printed paper at the end of the day. The researchers have also come up with a solution: a technology called “erasable paper,” for reducing paper wastage. Erasable paper is special paper that, once printed upon, gets erased on its own after a certain time period. The paper can therefore be used multiple times. An image is created on a special paper that Xerox has invented, by means of light exposure. There is no ink involved anywhere in the process, so there is no chemical pollution at any stage. Xerox is making preparations to make this commercially available soon.

The concern here for Xerox is that in the past,

they’ve been unable to successfully commercialise PARC innovations. Ethernet, the graphical user interface, and laser printing originated from PARC. Of these, Xerox has only profited from the commercialisation of laser printing. But now, erasable paper is a technology that every country will actively look forward to, since it makes for ecological as well as financial advantages.

AOL STEPS IN

India Online!

America Online (AOL) is the third-largest portal after Yahoo! and MSN. Last month, AOL officially launched its portal—

www.aol.in—in India. India being a big potential market for portals has attracted Microsoft, Yahoo!, and others as well; with a strength of more than 2,000 employees, AOL has had a presence in India since 2002, working on and building new services for AOL’s portal.

The AOL India portal has services like e-mail, IM, mobile services, Google-powered search, and channels like Bollywood, Cityguide, International Music, Education, and more. India is the first country to witness AOL’s next-generation e-mail services. It will offer users unlimited storage, industry-leading spam protection, and powerful virus protection.

Like the Yahoo! and MSN messengers, “cool” features like offline messaging, sharing of pictures, personalisation, and group messaging will be available in AOL Messenger. What would be different is multi-tab conversations and simultaneous logins through multiple AOL IDs. AOL will also provide video content from various content providers. In mobile services, along with VAS (Value Added Services) downloads; WAP Mail and AOL messenger will be made available.

In the future, more products and services will be made available, we have been told. The content will be made available in regional languages as well. AOL will add more content and channels by collaborating with their other partners, apart from Time Warner.

WHAT’S GOING ON?

FOSS: Business As Usual

As you already know, Microsoft has been going after the Free and Open Source Software (FOSS) community, attempting to sue them for violating 235 of its patents. Analysts called it a lame attempt to protect its intellectual property. The FOSS was disturbed for a while, but has now decided to just go ahead—business as usual.

The Linux Foundation Collaboration Summit was recently organised at Google’s Mountain view, California campus. About 200 open source developers, users, and software vendors were present. The Linux foundation group includes Intel, AMD, HP, IBM, Oracle, Novell, EMC, and Bank of America, amongst others.

The FOSS developers and software vendors discussed the future of the open source movement, and talked about—obviously—the patent infringement thing. Some of those present at summit referred to Microsoft as “the enemy,” while a few expressed the idea that Microsoft would never sue: James Bottomely, CTO, Steeleye Technologies, and Linux kernel developer said, “Since Linux customers also buy Microsoft, it’s unlikely of them... It’s just annoying and riled up.”

On another note, the Linux community is facing

Microsoft Surface

Everyone and their uncle is talking about the Microsoft Surface: it’s a coffee-table shaped computer with a 30-inch interactive display under a hard acrylic tabletop. Its interactive display is capable of multi-touch interaction, which is quite the buzz: you can access digital information by touching it, using natural gestures, and physical objects get recognised, too! For instance, place a digital camera (with a wireless chip) on the Surface, and data can be transferred to a media player through

hand gestures—this might sound unbelievable, but you’d better believe it! The best part is, it allows multiple users to interact with it simultaneously. Cameras are used inside the powder-coated steel frame to sense the touches, gestures, and objects.

The brilliant gadget—if we can call it a gadget—works without a mouse and keyboard. Currently, Microsoft has announced it will be sold for between \$5,000 and \$10,000 (Rs 2.25 to 4.5 lakh) initially to corporate customers. It will thereafter become more affordable for individuals.

Buzzword
of the MONTH